

# PLG 202 – Cities of the World: Systems and Societies

3 Units

**Instruction Mode & Meeting Times: Fully-Online, Asynchronous**

New Gen Ed Program: Building Connections with World Cultures & Societies Attribute

Gen Ed Tiers Program: Tier 2 Individuals and Societies

## Description of Course

This course introduces students to urban planning and the role of cities through the systems that compose the built environment and support urban societies. Students will explore how cities are organized through physical and social infrastructures such as water, energy, waste, transportation, jobs, and housing, among others. Through case studies of these urban systems from a range of international and US cities, students will learn about different approaches to meeting the material and social needs of collective life and situate them within their sociocultural contexts. Students will build connections among these systems to the urban experiences they structure by reading and interpreting a range of cultural texts that provide commentary on urban life, which include art, film, literature, and performance.

The course will show how the organization of cities shapes social life even as shared cultures shape the priorities and possibilities for urban planning. Students will consider the movement of urban planning ideas and apply their learning to imagine local changes to planning in their own built environment that promote sustainable, future-oriented cities in an interconnected world.

**Curriculum Category:** For students in the New Gen Ed Program, this is a Building Connections course with the World Cultures & Societies Attribute. It builds connections across the social positions and disciplines of the urban planner/social scientist and resident-user/humanist.

**Course Prerequisites:** There are no prerequisites for students in the New Gen Ed Program (entering Spring 2022 or later). For students in the Tiers General Education curriculum (entering prior to Spring 2022), prerequisites for this Tier 2 course are two (2) courses from Tier One: Individuals & Societies.

## Instructor and Contact Information

**Brian Bidolli, AICP, MBA, MCP, MPA**  
Lecturer, Sustainable Built Environments & Urban Planning  
College of Architecture, Planning & Landscape Architecture

**Email:** [bbidolli@arizona.edu](mailto:bbidolli@arizona.edu)

Office Hours: schedule by appointment via email

**All course information is available on D2L**

## University of Arizona Indigenous Land Acknowledgement

We respectfully acknowledge the University of Arizona is on the land and territories of Indigenous peoples. Today, Arizona is home to 22 federally recognized tribes, with Tucson being home to the O'odham and the Yaqui. Committed to diversity and inclusion, the University strives to build sustainable relationships with sovereign Native Nations and Indigenous communities through education offerings, partnerships, and community service.

# Course Format and Teaching Methods

The fully-online course will be administered through D2L. It includes recorded lectures, course readings, supplemental media, class discussions with video notes, and written assignments.

## Course Objectives

During this course students will:

1. **Describe** the role of cities and their planning and design by identifying fundamental components of urban organization and the people and professions involved in shaping the built environment. (CO 1)
2. **Evaluate** the physical and social infrastructures of cities by investigating their purposes, operations, performance, social effects, and future challenges in the face of climate change and the search for environmental sustainability. (CO 2)
3. **Recognize** historical and sociocultural specificities in approaches to urban planning by contextualizing examples of international and US cities within their urban origins, development, and future possibilities. (CO 3)
4. **Relate** international and US cities and recognize the movement of ideas among them to meet shared challenges and goals by comparing and contrasting case studies of urban planning and urban organization. (CO 4)
5. **Critically reflect** on the culture of cities as both shaped by and shaping city systems, which offers insights into their performance and social outcomes, by close-reading and interpreting cultural texts and products from international and US cities engaging with urban life and urbanism. (CO 5)
6. **Synthesize** an understanding of urban systems, their sociocultural impacts, urban cultures, and personal experiences by imagining and proposing local changes informed by global examples to promote sustainable, future-oriented cities in an interconnected world. (CO 6)

## Student Learning Outcomes

After completing this course, students will be able to advocate for concrete changes in their built environment with well-reasoned communications, which consider technical and social measures as well as global impacts, and participate in public processes of urban planning.

### Building Connections Learning Outcome

Students will demonstrate the ability to utilize multiple perspectives and make meaningful connections across disciplines and social positions, think conceptually and critically, and solve problems.

### World Cultures & Societies Learning Outcome

Students will describe, from one or multiple perspectives, the values, practices, and/or cultural products of at least one non-US culture/society; relate how these values, practices and/or cultural products have shaped their social, historical, political, environmental and/or geographic contexts; and reflect on how the student's own background has influenced their perceptions of other societies and their sense of place in the global community.

### Gen Ed Tiers Program Learning Outcomes

After taking Tier Two courses in Individuals and Societies students will be able to:

- understand more clearly issues of self-identity, social difference and social status, and the effects of major institutions on individual experiences
- demonstrate knowledge of the formal and informal structures and processes that make social systems, governments, and economies work
- have an informed opinion about socio-cultural problems and issues, which can be expressed orally or in writing, and based on knowledge about social, cultural, political, economic, philosophical, and religious theory
- demonstrate a well-developed critical faculty for distinguishing among the various theoretical and ideological interpretations of world events as they are presented in the media

## Course Requirements

### Course Communications

All course materials will be made available on [D2L](#). Course communications will be conducted through announcements on the dedicated D2L site and via official UA email—please check both often. The best way to reach me is by university email,. Students should maintain consistent and reliable access to the internet, email, D2L, and a computer for engaging, completing, and submitting coursework.

### Required Texts and Readings

All required texts and readings for this course will be provided through D2L. There are no special materials, tools, or supplies required.

### Writing Requirement (Gen Ed Tiers Program)

All Tier One and Tier Two General Education Courses are writing intensive (<https://gened.arizona.edu/course-guidelines/writing-requirement>).

Written assignments, both formal and informal, are incorporated at the end of each course module, in the term project and its components, and by student choice in weekly discussion responses. These will provide students with the opportunity to regularly receive and incorporate instructor feedback on their writing. Students are also given the opportunity to revise and resubmit a component of their term project for reevaluation. These assignments are due according to the course schedule, and add up to meet the minimum requirement of 10 pages or 2500 words over the term.

**Writing assignments are evaluated for format, organization, style, grammar, and punctuation, as well as content and participation in the scholarly conversation.**

**Please use the following file naming convention for written assignments submitted over D2L:**

**PLG202-FA23-AssignmentCode#-LastName\_FirstInitial.docx**

Example: **PLG202-FA23-WA2-Wong\_K.docx**

Assignment Codes and their description can be seen in the schedule below. In the example, “**PLG202-FA23-WA2-Wong\_K.docx**” would contain my response to the second Written Assignment (WA2) synthesizing Module 2 that is due in Week 7 of the course. Please include your name, the date, and title of the assignment within the document. Both Adobe **.pdf** and Microsoft Word **.docx** formats are generally accepted. Students may benefit from submitting .docx files for the term project so comments can be provided through tracked changes in Microsoft Word.

# Scheduled Topics and Assignments

Course topics and assignments are planned over the semester as follows:

| Assignment Category: |                                                   | Weekly Discussion Post & Peer Responses |                          |                     |                                |                                                            |  |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------|---------------------|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|--|
|                      |                                                   |                                         | Written Assignments (WA) |                     |                                |                                                            |  |
|                      |                                                   |                                         |                          | Course Journal (CJ) |                                |                                                            |  |
|                      |                                                   |                                         |                          |                     | Term Project & Components (TP) |                                                            |  |
| Week                 | Topic                                             |                                         |                          |                     | Assignment Code & Description  |                                                            |  |
| 1                    | Introduction and Overview                         | 10                                      | --                       | 10                  | --                             | CJ1: Entry Response                                        |  |
| 2                    | Urban Systems and Societies                       | 10                                      | --                       | --                  | --                             |                                                            |  |
| 3                    | The "____" City                                   | 10                                      | 25                       | --                  | --                             | WA1: Module 1 Synthesis                                    |  |
| 4                    | City Form and Transformations                     | 10                                      | --                       | --                  | --                             |                                                            |  |
| 5                    | Land and Housing                                  | 10                                      | --                       | --                  | 30                             | TP1: Research on an Urban System                           |  |
| 6                    | Networks and Transportation                       | 10                                      | --                       | --                  | --                             |                                                            |  |
| 7                    | Industry and Jobs                                 | 10                                      | 35                       | --                  | 30                             | WA2: Module 2 Synthesis<br>TP2: Evaluate & Compare Options |  |
| 8                    | Energy                                            | 10                                      | --                       | 40                  |                                | CJ2: Midpoint Check                                        |  |
| 9                    | Water                                             | 10                                      | --                       | --                  | 30                             | TP3: Translate Policy and Project Outcomes                 |  |
| 10                   | Waste                                             | 10                                      | --                       | --                  | --                             |                                                            |  |
| 11                   | Food                                              | 10                                      | 35                       | --                  | 0*                             | WA3: Module 3 Synthesis<br>TP4: Revise & Resubmit          |  |
| 12                   | Public Space                                      | 10                                      | --                       | --                  | --                             |                                                            |  |
| 13                   | Participation                                     | 10                                      | --                       | --                  | --                             |                                                            |  |
| 14                   | Sustainability<br>(Review / Thanksgiving Holiday) | 10                                      | --                       | --                  | --                             |                                                            |  |
| 15                   | Equity                                            | 10                                      | 30                       | 40                  | --                             | WA4: Module 4 Synthesis<br>CJ3: Journal Submission         |  |
| 16                   | Reflection and Finals                             | 10                                      | --                       | 10                  | 35                             | CJ4: Exit Reflection<br>TP5: Final Policy Memo or Op-Ed    |  |
|                      |                                                   | -10                                     | --                       | --                  | --                             | one discussion post dropped                                |  |
|                      |                                                   | 150                                     | 125                      | 100                 | 125                            | / 500 total course points                                  |  |
|                      |                                                   | 30%                                     | 25%                      | 20%                 | 25%                            | weight of assignment categories                            |  |

## Weekly Discussion Post & Peer Responses (30%)

Students will be responsible for weekly D2L posts to demonstrate thoughtful participation in the course and lively engagement with their peers to create a community of learners. Discussion prompts will be posted at the start of each week and vary over the course. Students will have ample time to explore, reflect, and compose their responses alongside the course lecture, readings, and other additional media or assignments.

Students will respond to the weekly discussion prompt and post a D2L video note. Each original discussion post should be approximately **two to three (2–3) minutes long**. Often posts will benefit from, and may even require, **visual slides** to illustrate one's responses. Students are expected to provide and post one to two (1–2) slides along with their video note whenever necessary and reference them in their video note. Note that these are separate objects within a single discussion post because D2L video notes do not allow screen sharing while recording. Slides can be creatively composed with any combination of text and images in any program (such as Microsoft PowerPoint/Word, Google Docs/Slides, Adobe Illustrator/InDesign), exported as a single image file, and then uploaded to the discussion post.

Students are also responsible for viewing and responding to discussion posts, and generous engagement is highly encouraged. Responses must be respectful, relevant, and substantive. They should be between one to two **(1–2) minutes long by video note or 150 to 200 words in writing**. Students are expected to **read at least half** of the class discussion posts each week, and reading **two-thirds of posts** will earn full credit for engagement.

Full points for weekly discussions require all of these dimensions: an original video note post, responses to at least two (2) peers on D2L, and viewing a significant portion of the class discussion. One discussion post will be dropped from the final calculation of grades.

## Written Assignments (25%)

Students are also responsible for demonstrating their understanding and engagement with lectures, readings, and other materials through written assignments at the end of each course module. They will require a range of reading comprehension, application of concepts, evaluation of information, and creative, critical thinking to synthesize content from the full module.

Responses should be **400 to 500 words** in length and fully address all parts of the prompt. Written assignments must include **appropriate citations to course materials and additional references to support their responses**, and are required to be clearly composed according to academic conventions with complete sentences, structured paragraphs, correct spelling, and proper grammar.

## Course Journal (20%)

Each student will contribute to a running Course Journal that tracks and reflects upon their engagement with the course, urban systems, and the urban life they contribute to. The journal is intended as a low-stakes assignment that guides students to freely reflect on their changing knowledge and experience within their environment throughout the term, nurture their curiosity with new connections, and to take part in the reflective process of planning and professional practice.

The Course Journal should be structured as a **single Word or Google Doc** that contains an **250 to 300 word entry for each week of the course**. Students are encouraged to write freely to create a reflective and analytic response, which could include:

- Connecting to course materials and responding to personal use and experiences with urban systems. *How did urban planning appear and shape your life this week?*
- Engaging with current news and planning ideas that appear in public. *What's at stake, and how do they connect to broader systems and management of the urban environment?*
- Investigating topics that capture your interest to learn and share more. *Where would you like to dig for further understanding, and how might it connect with your career goals?*
- Exploring expressions of culture by describing and interpreting creative works and texts. *How do these expressions participate and comment on public and shared urban life?*

The Course Journal will be submitted four times over the term and includes a course **entry response and an exit reflection** to bookend the collection of weekly entries. Further details on the format and range of responses possible will be shared over D2L.

**Students must include responses for each week of class up to the scheduled submission dates**

## **Term Project: Policy Memo or Opinion Editorial (25%)**

The term project (i.e., summative assessment), is a Policy Memo or Opinion Editorial where students will investigate and apply their learning from the course to propose a change in how a system within their city of choice works or uplift an idea from it that could be applied more broadly. This could be the adoption of a policy, technology, process, mode of administration, or way of thinking that would improve outcomes for the future.

The option between two formats addresses different audiences that are both crucial in guiding urban change: public officials responsible for urban administration and the public at large that uses urban systems. Students will craft succinct, well-evidenced arguments to persuade their selected audience to adopt a specific, measurable idea. They must demonstrate an understanding and engagement with urban life and systems in both their material and social dimensions. Students will draw upon course content, research examples from different contexts, and build connections across perspectives as both residents-users and advisors-planners to advocate for urban planning ideas that prepare a city of their choice for the future.

The term project is scaffolded throughout the course, starting with components approximately **500 to 600 words long (TP1 & TP2)** and a roughly midpoint submission of **800 to 1,000 words (TP3)**. Students will use these assignments to build towards a successful final project with sections of writing, and the **final written submission will be 1,000 to 1,200 words long**.

The components guide students to: propose an urban system to investigate in a city of their choice, research and describe its organization, and identify a crucial development in its formation. Students will build upon these findings to evaluate its function and potentials for change. They will then research and describe how the system operates in a different context, relate the two approaches through comparisons and contrasts, and critically reflect on how ideas might translate across contexts to improve urban outcomes.

Students will synthesize and distill work from the preceding components to create a compelling final Policy Memo or Opinion Editorial. Students will have the opportunity to **revise and resubmit** a prior component submission of the term project for reevaluation (**TP4**). This will provide an opportunity to increase their initial assignment score, incorporate instructor feedback, and receive further guidance as they prepare for their final submission. More details on the term project and its components will be provided on D2L.

Term projects will be graded on a rubric that considers the level to which students:

1. Define a specific issue within a selected urban system.
2. Define key decision-makers to address and the public audience that will take interest.
3. Assess the current state of that system with its purpose, impacts, challenges, and goals.
4. Reference and demonstrate knowledge of how that system is structured and operates elsewhere.
5. Situate the adoption of new approaches with how they translate and change across sociocultural contexts.
6. Build an accessible and persuasive case for their proposed changes in future planning.
7. Communicate ideas clearly to a key audience in a Policy Memo or Opinion Editorial format.

## Final Examination or Project

In lieu of a final examination, this course has a summative assessment that is due during the week of final exams. Please refer to the Term Project description above and further information on D2L.

## Grading Scale and Policies

Points for the course will be distributed according to the schedule of assignments and evaluated as described above. Final grades are based on the following percentages of total course points available:

|               |              |              |              |                   |
|---------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|-------------------|
| A = 90 – 100% | B = 80 – 89% | C = 70 – 79% | D = 60 – 69% | E = 59% and below |
|---------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|-------------------|

This course follows the “40%” rule for General Education Tier One and Tier Two courses, which means that students will complete at least 40% of the grade-points by the end of the 8<sup>th</sup> week of classes so that they have ample feedback on their performance prior to the 10-week deadline to drop a course.

## Late Work Policy

Late work will not be accepted past the due date unless the student has experienced a medical situation. It is the instructor's discretion whether or not points will be deducted for late work with a documented excuse.

## Incomplete (I) or Withdrawal (W)

Requests for incomplete (I) or withdrawal (W) must be made in accordance with University policies, which are available at: <http://catalog.arizona.edu/policy/grades-and-grading-system#incomplete> and <http://catalog.arizona.edu/policy/grades-and-grading-system#Withdrawal> respectively.

## Dispute of Grade Policy

Should a student wish to dispute the received grade on an assignment, paper, or project, they must submit a formal request in writing, along with rationale, within one (1) week of receiving the grade.

## Honors Credit

All Tier One and Tier Two General Education courses must be available for Honors credit. Students wishing to complete this course for Honors credit should contact the instructor within the first two (2) weeks of class to discuss and develop their ideas into an Honors Contract well before the contract due date. For Fall 2023, the Honors Contract due date is **Monday, September 11, 2023**. Honors contract information is available at <https://www.honors.arizona.edu/honors-contracts>.

## Generative AI Use

In this course, generative artificial intelligence/large-language-models tools, such as ChatGPT, Dall-e, Bard, Bing, are **generally not acceptable** for producing work submitted for grading. This course policy is driven by the learning goals and desired learning outcomes for the course, which require students to explore and demonstrate ongoing engagement with the built environment and urban systems in their own environment and across diverse settings—meaning that thoughtful participation in the course requires reflecting upon your own lived experiences as an urban resident. If you are considering ways to use generative AI tools appropriately in this course, which require attribution and citation, I encourage you to discuss your process with me in advance. Uncited use and submission of AI-produced work may constitute breach of the Code of Academic Integrity.

## Additional Course and University Policies

### Makeup Policy for Students Who Register Late

Students who register after the first class meeting (or week if online-only) must contact the instructor immediately to agree upon a fair deadline for missed work to be completed.

### Absence and Class Participation Policy

The UA's policy concerning Class Attendance, Participation, and Administrative Drops is available at <https://catalog.arizona.edu/policy/class-attendance-and-participation>.

The UA policy regarding absences for any sincerely held religious belief, observance or practice will be accommodated where reasonable: <http://policy.arizona.edu/human-resources/religious-accommodation-policy>.

Absences preapproved by the UA Dean of Students (or dean's designee) will be honored. See <http://policy.arizona.edu/employmenthuman-resources/attendance>.

Participating in the course and attending lectures and other course events are vital to the learning

process. As such, attendance is required at all lectures and discussion section meetings. Absences may affect a student's final course grade. If you anticipate being absent, are unexpectedly absent, or are unable to participate in class online activities, please contact me as soon as possible. To request a disability-related accommodation to this attendance policy, please contact the Disability Resource Center at (520) 621-3268 or [drc-info@arizona.edu](mailto:drc-info@arizona.edu). If you are experiencing unexpected barriers to your success in your courses, the Dean of Students Office is a central support resource for all students and may be helpful. The Dean of Students Office is located in the Robert L. Nugent Building, Room 100, or call 520-621-7057.

### Classroom Behavior Policy

To foster a positive learning environment, students and instructors have a shared responsibility. We want a safe, welcoming, and inclusive environment where all of us feel comfortable with each other and where we can challenge ourselves to succeed. To that end, our focus is on the tasks at hand and not on extraneous activities (e.g., texting, chatting, reading a newspaper, making phone calls, web surfing, etc.).

## Threatening Behavior Policy

The UA Threatening Behavior by Students Policy prohibits threats of physical harm to any member of the University community, including to oneself. See

<https://policy.arizona.edu/education-and-student-affairs/threatening-behavior-students>.

## Accessibility and Accommodations

At the University of Arizona, we strive to make learning experiences as accessible as possible. If you anticipate or experience barriers based on disability or pregnancy, please contact the Disability Resource Center (520-621-3268, <https://drc.arizona.edu/>) to establish reasonable accommodations.

## Code of Academic Integrity

Students are encouraged to share intellectual views and discuss freely the principles and applications of course materials. However, graded work/exercises must be the product of independent effort unless otherwise instructed. Students are expected to adhere to the UA Code of Academic Integrity as described in the UA General Catalog. See <https://deanofstudents.arizona.edu/policies/code-academic-integrity>.

The University Libraries have some excellent tips for avoiding plagiarism, available at <https://new.library.arizona.edu/research/citing/plagiarism>.

**Please respect the use of course material within the specific timeframe, educational setting, and purposes for which you are accessing and using it with me. This content is protected and may not be shared, uploaded, or distributed.** Selling class notes and/or other course materials to other students or to a third party for resale is not permitted without the instructor's express written consent. Violations to this and other course rules are subject to the Code of Academic Integrity and may result in course sanctions. Additionally, students who use D2L or UA email to sell or buy these copyrighted materials are subject to Code of Conduct Violations for misuse of student email

addresses. This conduct may also constitute copyright infringement.

## UA Nondiscrimination and Anti-harassment Policy

The University is committed to creating and maintaining an environment free of discrimination; see <http://policy.arizona.edu/human-resources/nondiscrimination-and-anti-harassment-policy>.

Our classroom is a place where everyone is encouraged to express well-formed opinions and their reasons for those opinions. We also want to create a tolerant and open environment where such opinions can be expressed without resorting to bullying or discrimination of others.

## Campus Pantry

Any student who has difficulty affording groceries or accessing sufficient food to eat every day, or who lacks a safe and stable place to live and believes this may affect their performance in the course, is urged to contact the Dean of Students for support. In addition, the University of Arizona Campus Pantry is open for students to receive supplemental groceries at no cost. Please see their website at: <https://campuspantry.arizona.edu/> for open times.

## Additional Resources for Students

UA Academic Policies and Procedures are available at <https://catalog.arizona.edu/policies>.

Student Assistance and Advocacy information is available at <https://deanofstudents.arizona.edu/support/student-assistance>.

### Campus Health

<http://www.health.arizona.edu/>

Campus Health provides quality medical and mental health care services through virtual and in-person care.

Phone: 520-621-9202

### Counseling and Psych Services (CAPS)

<https://health.arizona.edu/counseling-psych-services>

CAPS provides mental health care, including short-term counseling services.

Phone: 520-621-3334

### **The Dean of Students Office's Student Assistance Program**

<https://deanofstudents.arizona.edu/support/student-assistance>

Student Assistance helps students manage crises, life traumas, and other barriers that impede success. The staff addresses the needs of students who experience issues related to social adjustment, academic challenges, psychological health, physical health, victimization, and relationship issues, through a variety of interventions, referrals, and follow up services.

Email: [DOS-deanofstudents@arizona.edu](mailto:DOS-deanofstudents@arizona.edu)

Phone: 520-621-7057

### **Survivor Advocacy Program**

<https://survivoradvocacy.arizona.edu/>

The Survivor Advocacy Program provides confidential support and advocacy services to student survivors of sexual and gender-based violence. The Program can also advise students about relevant non-UA resources available within the local community for support.

Email: [survivoradvocacy@arizona.edu](mailto:survivoradvocacy@arizona.edu)

Phone: 520-621-5767

## **Preferred Gender Pronoun**

This course affirms people of all gender expressions and gender identities. If you prefer to be called a different name than what is on the class roster, please let me know. Feel free to correct instructors on your preferred gender pronoun. If you have any questions or concerns, please do not hesitate to contact me directly in class or via email (instructor email). If you wish to change your preferred name or pronoun in the UAccess system, please use the following guidelines:

- **Preferred name:** University of Arizona students may choose to identify themselves within the University community using a preferred first name that differs from their official/legal name. A student's preferred name will appear instead of the person's official/legal first name in select University-related systems and documents, provided that the name is not being used for the purpose of

misrepresentation. Students are able to update their preferred names in UAccess.

- **Pronouns:** Students may designate pronouns they use to identify themselves. Instructors and staff are encouraged to use pronouns for people that they use for themselves as a sign of respect and inclusion. Students are able to update and edit their pronouns in UAccess.

More information on updating your preferred name and pronouns is available on the Office of the Registrar site at

<https://www.registrar.arizona.edu/>.

## **Confidentiality of Student Records**

The Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act of 1974, commonly referred to as FERPA or the Buckley amendment, is a federal law designed to protect the privacy of a student's educational record. With only a few exceptions, student educational records are considered confidential and may not be released without the written consent of the student. For more information on the rights granted to students under this legislation, see: <https://registrar.arizona.edu/privacy-ferpa/ferpa-compliance>.

## **Subject to Change Statement**

Information contained in the course syllabus, other than the grade and absence policy, may be subject to change with advance notice, as deemed appropriate by the instructor.